

50 Action and state verbs

Verbs that describe actions or events are known as “action” or “dynamic” verbs, whereas those that describe states are known as “state” or “stative” verbs.

See also:

Present simple **1** Present continuous **4**

Past simple **7** Past continuous **10**

50.1 ACTION AND STATE VERBS

Action verbs usually describe what people or things do.
State verbs usually say how things are or how someone feels.

ACTION VERB

I { **read**
am reading } a book.

Action verbs can be used in simple forms and continuous forms.



STATE VERB

I **love** books.

State verbs are not usually used in the continuous form.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Dominic **is eating** ice cream.



Gayle **is lying** on the couch.



I **don't eat** meat. I'm a vegetarian.



I **want** to go away somewhere.



She **has** two cats and a dog.



We've **known** each other for years.



COMMON MISTAKES USING STATE VERBS IN CONTINUOUS TENSES

Most state verbs cannot be used in continuous forms.



State verbs are only usually used in the simple form.

I **want** a new laptop. ✓

I **am wanting** a new laptop. ✗

State verbs can't usually be used in continuous forms.